

Openings with Reasons

Develop with a purpose, get the king safe legally, and value a useful tempo.

WHO THIS BOOK IS FOR

Players who know how the pieces move and want to make better decisions. Use a board if notation is new. Books 01-08 need no endgame theory; read Book 09 before the more demanding rook examples in Book 10.

THREE LESSONS. EACH HAS A MODEL, AN EXERCISE AND AN EXPLAINED ANSWER.

01 Develop toward the central struggle

P. 3

02 Castling has conditions

P. 6

03 Gain a tempo without chasing blindly

P. 9

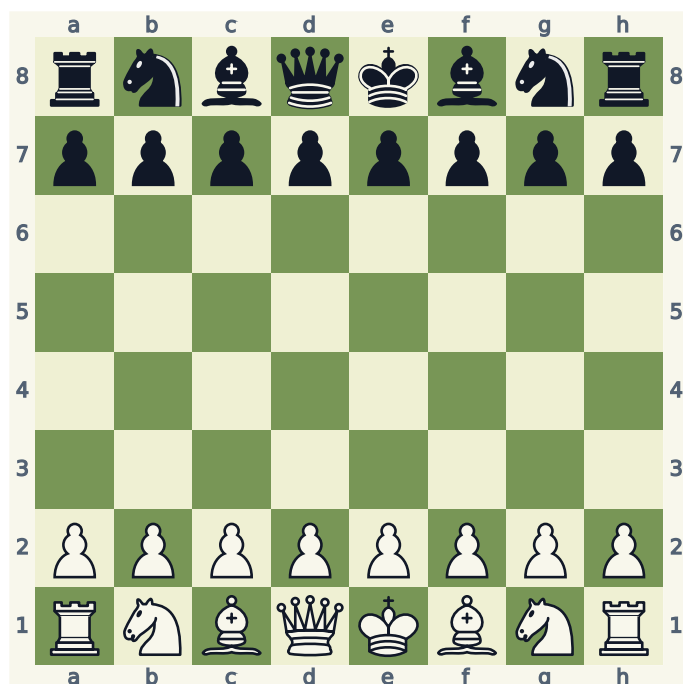
A practical study session

Spend 5 minutes reading the model, 5 minutes solving without the answer, and 5 minutes explaining the solution aloud. Spend another 5 minutes playing the position from both sides. Study one lesson per day; repeat its exercise tomorrow and a week later.

What counts as learning: name the relevant fact, show the opponent's reply, and explain what remains. A move guessed without a reason earns only partial credit. The goal is a repeatable decision, not a memorized diagram.

Use the board, then the move list

Every diagram says who moves. Boards face that player; file letters and rank numbers remain authoritative.



NOTATION YOU WILL SEE

1. K = king, Q = queen, R = rook, B = bishop, N = knight. A pawn move has no piece letter.
2. Nf3 means a knight moves to f3. Rxc6 means a rook captures on c6.
3. + means check; # means checkmate. O-O means kingside castling. e8=Q means promotion to a queen.
4. 1... means Black moves first in that line. Read one move, make it on a board, then read the reply.

THE SAME THINKING ROUTINE IN EVERY CHAPTER

1. Check the immediate threat.
2. List two sensible candidates.
3. Test the opponent's checks, captures and threats.
4. Inspect the final board: material, king safety, piece activity and pawn structure.

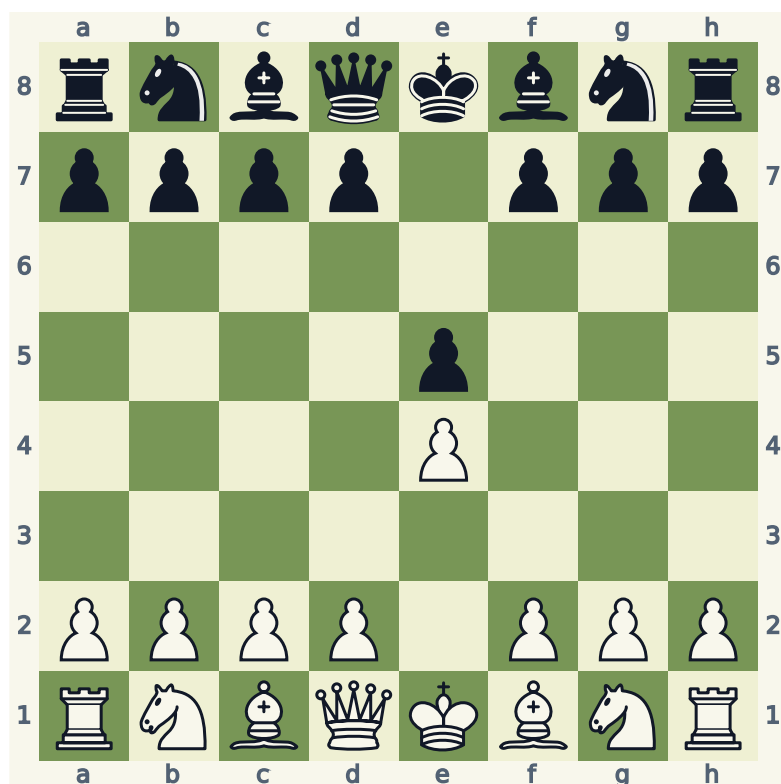
Read the claim carefully. A sample line may illustrate a plan without forcing every reply. Some exercises ask for a safe move, a legal move or a correct diagnosis rather than a unique best move. A tablebase gives an exact result for the specified small ending; an engine check supports a line but is not a proof of every strategic claim.

Replay and revisit. The web edition includes every explanation. Download its PGN file to load the model and exercise positions into a chess program; each starts from a FEN position code. No account or software is needed to read the PDF or website.

Develop toward the central struggle

Opening moves should do visible work: influence the center, develop pieces to useful squares, and prepare king safety. Principles help you generate candidates; threats decide the move.

MODEL A / WHITE TO MOVE



READ THESE FACTS FIRST

1. The pawns on e4 and e5 contest central squares.
2. Nf3 develops a knight and attacks the e5-pawn.
3. Moving the knight and f1-bishop prepares kingside castling, subject to its safety conditions.

WORKED SEQUENCE

2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4

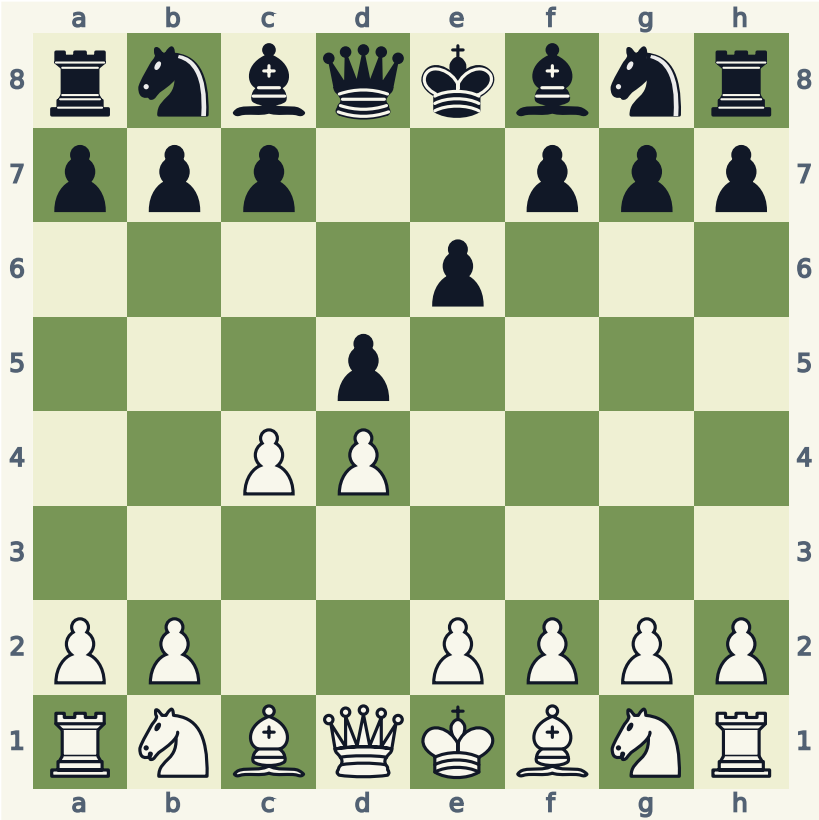
Nf3 develops with a target. Black can answer ...Nc6, defending e5 while bringing out a piece. Bc4 then develops the bishop and looks toward f7.

These are useful moves because their jobs can be explained from the board. They are not a script to follow regardless of the opponent. If Black creates a concrete threat or changes the center, stop and inspect that change before making your next familiar move.

Your turn: inspect the changed position

Work for five minutes before turning the page. Write the reason and the opponent's reply, even if you recognize the pattern.

EXERCISE B / WHITE TO MOVE



- 1. Which central square does Nc3 help White control?
- 2. Why is ...Nf6 a sensible black reply?
- 3. Give White's next developing move and one job it performs.

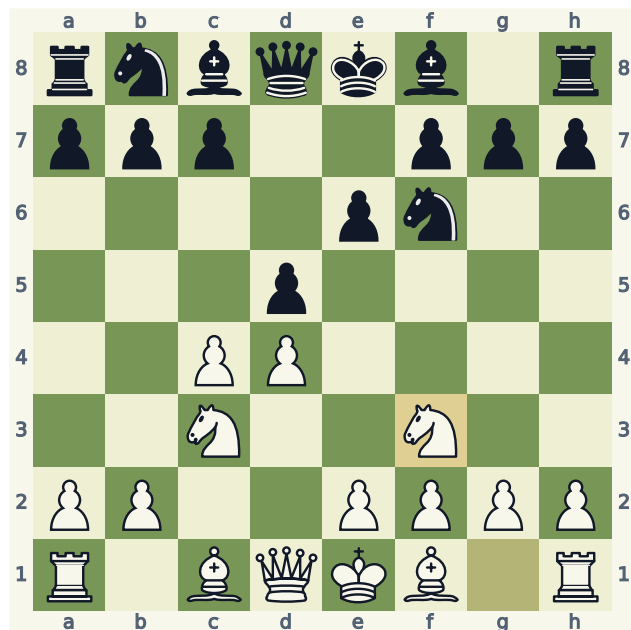
MY CANDIDATE, THE REPLY I EXPECT, AND THE REASON

Position code (FEN): rnbqkbnr/ppp2ppp/4p3/3p4/2PP4/8/PP2PPPP/RNBQKBNR w KQkq - 0 3

Check your reasoning

3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3

EXERCISE B / AFTER THE SAMPLE LINE



1. Nc3 attacks d5 and e4. The d5-pawn is the central point of contact with White's c4-pawn. The knight also develops toward the center.

2. ...Nf6 develops a knight and protects d5. It helps Black maintain the central pawn rather than reacting to development with an unrelated move.

3. Nf3 develops the other knight, controls d4 and e5, and clears g1 for eventual castling. White still needs to move the f1-bishop and verify king safety before castling. Several sound opening continuations exist.

WHERE THE IDEA CAN FAIL

Do not turn development into a counting contest. A developed piece on an unsafe square is worse than an undeveloped piece that can enter safely next turn.

TRANSFER TO YOUR OWN GAMES

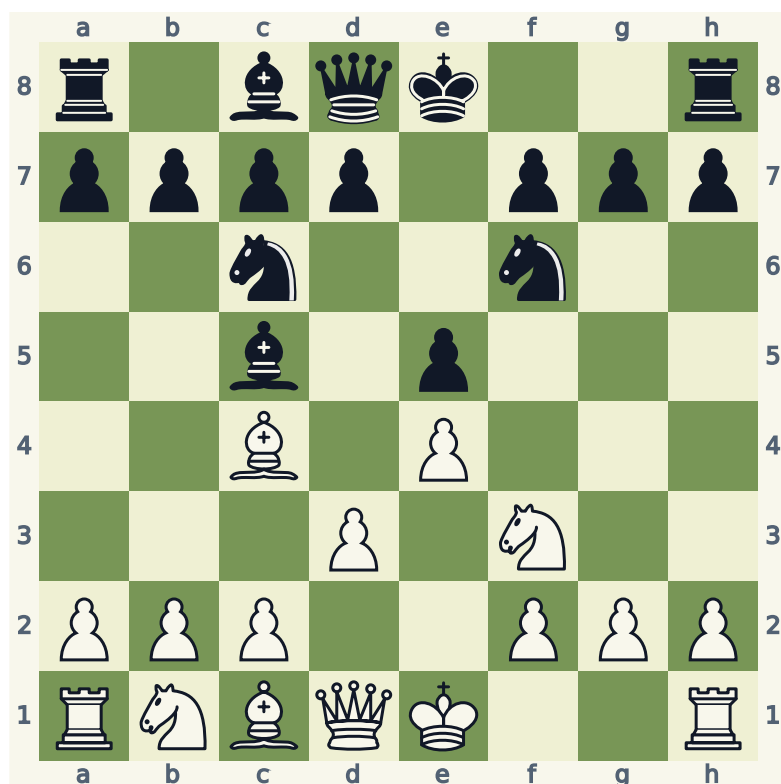
For the first ten moves of one game, write a short job beside each move. If a move only says "it is theory," find its actual target, defense or preparation.

Score your explanation: give 1 point for the relevant fact and 1 for the consequence in each of the three answers (6 total). At 4 or below, replay the model and try again tomorrow. A different legal plan can earn full credit when it satisfies the question and survives the opponent's reply.

Castling has conditions

Castling is a king move with strict conditions. Clear squares are necessary, but the king also needs a safe starting square, transit square and destination.

MODEL A / WHITE TO MOVE



READ THESE FACTS FIRST

1. White's king and h1-rook retain castling rights.
2. The squares f1 and g1 are empty.
3. The king is not in check, and neither f1 nor g1 is attacked by Black.

WORKED SEQUENCE

5. O-O d6 6. c3

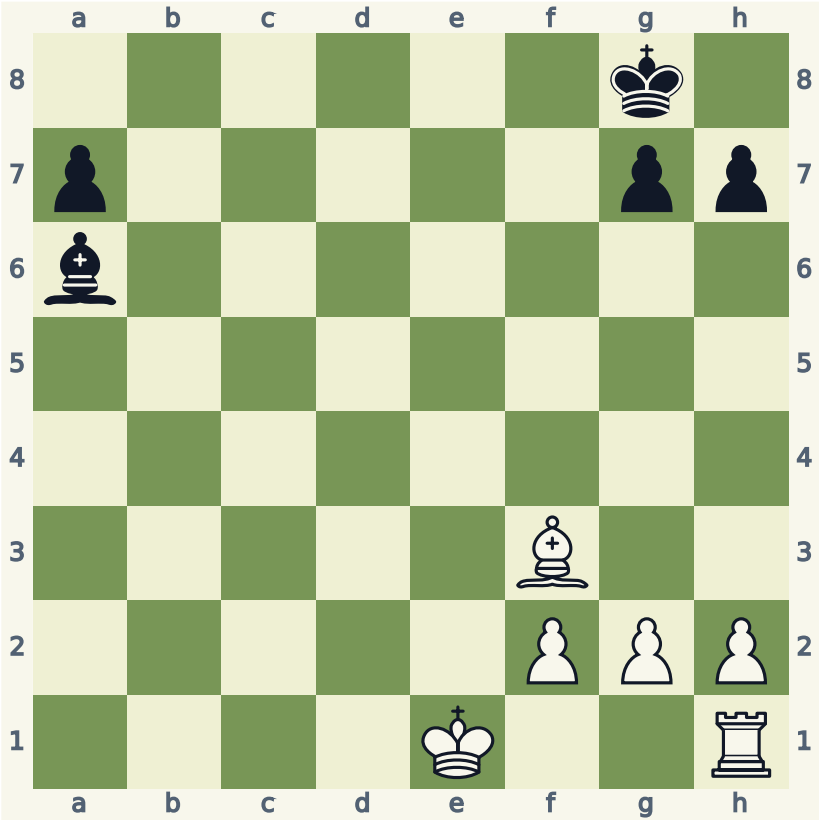
O-O moves the white king from e1 to g1 and the rook from h1 to f1. White improves king shelter and brings the rook nearer the center in one move.

The sample continuation ...d6 c3 supports a future central plan. Before playing it in a game, inspect Black's reply. Castling has improved safety, but it has not removed the need to check threats on every turn.

Your turn: inspect the changed position

Work for five minutes before turning the page. Write the reason and the opponent's reply, even if you recognize the pattern.

EXERCISE B / WHITE TO MOVE



- 1. Which square does Black's bishop on a6 attack along a6-b5-c4-d3-e2-f1?
- 2. Is O-O legal despite White retaining castling rights?
- 3. What does the example Be2 ...Bxe2 Kxe2 accomplish, and what right does White lose?

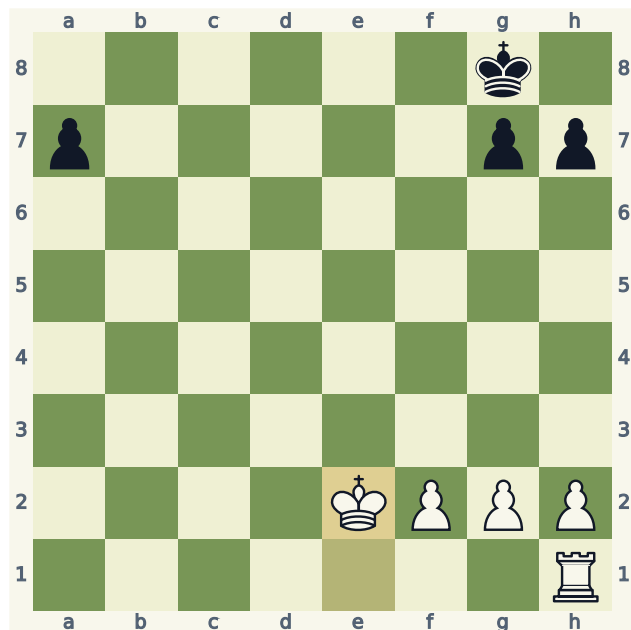
MY CANDIDATE, THE REPLY I EXPECT, AND THE REASON

Position code (FEN): 6k1/p5pp/b7/8/8/5B2/5PPP/4K2R w K - 0 1

Check your reasoning

1. Be2 Bxe2 2. Kxe2

EXERCISE B / AFTER THE SAMPLE LINE



1. The bishop attacks f1, the square the king would cross. The path between a6 and f1 is clear in this diagram.

2. No. White cannot castle through the attacked square f1. Castling rights record move history; they do not guarantee that castling is legal now.

3. Be2 blocks the diagonal. If Black exchanges with ...Bxe2, Kxe2 removes that bishop. Moving the king permanently gives up castling rights. This illustrates a legal way to resolve the diagonal, not a uniquely best conversion of White's large material advantage.

WHERE THE IDEA CAN FAIL

You cannot castle out of check, through check, or into check. You also lose the relevant right after moving the king or that rook, even if it returns to its original square. An attacked rook does not by itself forbid castling.

TRANSFER TO YOUR OWN GAMES

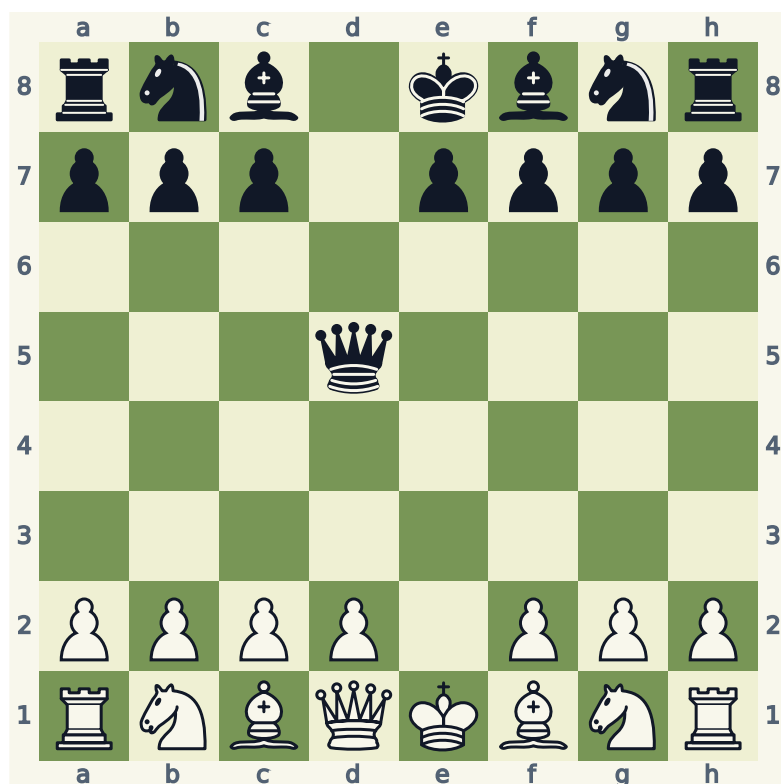
Before castling in three practice games, point to the king's starting, crossing and destination squares and name any enemy attacks on them.

Score your explanation: give 1 point for the relevant fact and 1 for the consequence in each of the three answers (6 total). At 4 or below, replay the model and try again tomorrow. A different legal plan can earn full credit when it satisfies the question and survives the opponent's reply.

Gain a tempo without chasing blindly

Developing with an attack can gain a tempo: the opponent must spend a turn dealing with your threat. Verify that the developing piece really attacks its target.

MODEL A / WHITE TO MOVE



READ THESE FACTS FIRST

1. Black's queen has recaptured on d5.
2. A knight developed to c3 attacks d5 directly.
3. White can use the queen's retreat to occupy the center with d4.

WORKED SEQUENCE

3. Nc3 Qa5 4. d4

Nc3 develops a piece while attacking the queen. After ...Qa5, d4 establishes a central pawn and opens the c1-bishop's diagonal.

Do not keep chasing the queen just because the first attack worked. Compare the usefulness of the next developing move with the time and squares you would give up to attack it again. The queen on a5 is not automatically trapped.

Your turn: inspect the changed position

Work for five minutes before turning the page. Write the reason and the opponent's reply, even if you recognize the pattern.

EXERCISE B / WHITE TO MOVE



- Does Bd2 attack the queen on a5 in the exercise?
- Which piece interrupts that diagonal?
- Can Bd2 still be a useful move without an immediate threat to the queen?

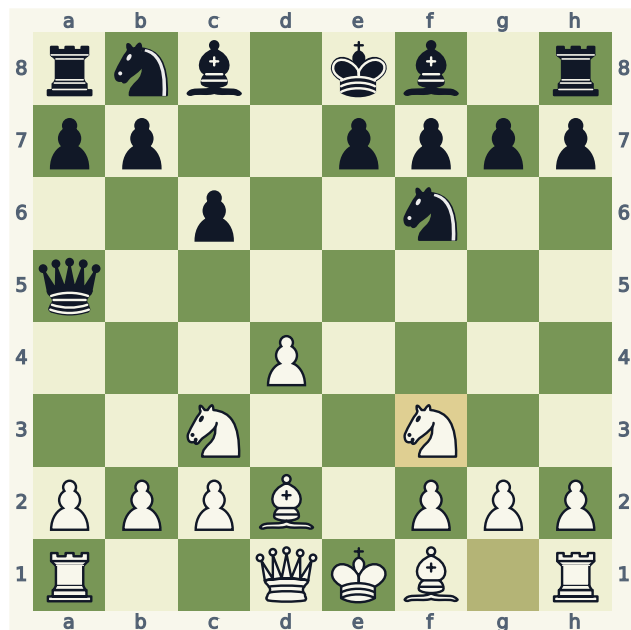
MY CANDIDATE, THE REPLY I EXPECT, AND THE REASON

Position code (FEN): rnb1kbnr/pp2pppp/2p5/q7/3P4/2N5/PPP2PPP/R1BQKBNR w KQkq - 0 5

Check your reasoning

5. Bd2 Nf6 6. Nf3

EXERCISE B / AFTER THE SAMPLE LINE



1. No. The diagonal is d2-c3-b4-a5, and the bishop's line stops at c3. Black is not forced to move the queen in response to Bd2.

2. White's own knight stands on c3. Bishops cannot attack through friendly pieces. Calling this an attack on the queen would miscount the tempo.

3. Yes. Bd2 develops the bishop and can prepare future ideas if the knight moves. In the sample ...Nf6 Nf3, both sides continue development. A useful quiet move does not need to be described as a forcing move to justify it.

WHERE THE IDEA CAN FAIL

A diagonal that points toward the queen may be blocked by your own piece. Describe the actual attack, including intervening squares, before claiming that you gained a tempo.

TRANSFER TO YOUR OWN GAMES

For each developing move you call "with tempo," name the threatened capture and trace its path. If no legal threat exists, evaluate the move on its quieter merits.

Score your explanation: give 1 point for the relevant fact and 1 for the consequence in each of the three answers (6 total). At 4 or below, replay the model and try again tomorrow. A different legal plan can earn full credit when it satisfies the question and survives the opponent's reply.

Remember it without the diagram

CLOSE THE BOOK. ANSWER THESE THREE QUESTIONS FROM MEMORY.

1. What three useful jobs often justify an opening move?
2. Can the king castle through an attacked square if the final square is safe?
3. Why does Bd2 not attack Qa5 here?

CHECK YOUR ANSWERS AFTER YOU HAVE TRIED

1. Central influence, safe development, and preparation for king safety.
2. No. The starting, transit and destination king squares must all satisfy the castling safety rules.
3. The white knight on c3 blocks the diagonal d2-c3-b4-a5.

Checking and scope. Original teaching positions and explanations, with standard opening sequences where indicated. All 6 starting positions and listed moves in this book were checked for legality. Stockfish 19 reviewed candidates at depth 18; available positions with 7 or fewer pieces were also checked against the Lichess tablebase. Strategic examples do not claim unique best play. These AI-assisted materials are not a substitute for checking an unfamiliar continuation on a board.

PRIMARY REFERENCES AND FURTHER PRACTICE

[Lichess practice: tactics and endgames](#)

[Lichess opposition practice](#)

[Lichess basic rook endgames](#)

[Stockfish: official engine](#)

[Lichess tablebase API](#)

Edition 1.0 | 2026-09-10 | Lesson text: 1d42c4. Chess piece artwork: Colin M. L. Burnett (Cburnett), GPLv2+. Full artwork source, credits, position data and validation notes are in the repository. Report a correction with the book, lesson ID and exact move.